

Y.S.R. Reddy and B.S. Hooda put together a dossier on 40 MPs across the political spectrum. These included five from Uttar Pradesh, four from Madhya Pradesh, three each from Gujarat, Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh, eight from Karnataka and five from the North-east. The list was culled using friendly political contacts, chief ministers in UPA states and friendly dissidents in the Opposition ranks. The bottom line seemed to be "impossible is nothing" and their credo was "just do it".

Armed with a war chest of promises and promissory notes, MPs, ministers and general secretaries worked the speed-dials on their mobile phones and the country to lure the vulnerable and the amenable. And displaying an astounding strike rate, they got 24 of the 40 targeted in the bag—10 abstaining and 14 voting across the political fence in defiance of party whips. To get a sense of the magnitude of cross voting organised, consider this: if these 24 MPs were to have voted with their parties, the UPA score would have been 251. Even if one were to

dub abstentions as genuine, the score would have been 261, well short of majority.

The contrast was stark. If the UPA team displayed an uncanny sense of purpose, the NDA was in total disarray. Of the 24 MPs, eight were from the BJP, including four from Karnataka where they had just won the Assembly polls riding a popular wave. If the NDA was missing the presence of a Pramod Mahajan amidst them to effect split second acquisitions, the UPA seemed to have found its version in Amar Singh. The blend of gut-wrenching reality unleashed by the Samajwadi Party MP and the sophisticated but ruthless methods of the Congress brought dividends. Unlike BJP, the Congress used its best players, not mid-level functionaries and independent Rajya Sabha MPs. The BJP's failure is best reflected in how the Congress snagged JMM leader Shibu Soren right out of the NDA net to add five MPs to its tally. Soren had been wooed by the BJP which had offered him the post of chief minister of Jharkhand if he delivered five MPs. But even as he dwelled on it, the



The Absentees

The absence of eight NDA MPs during the confidence vote was the reason behind a glum Opposition

D.K. AUDIKESAVULU



NAIDU, TDP,
ANDHRA
PRADESH:

Says that he followed the party whip; claims his vote was declared invalid. Was the treasurer of state Congress before joining TDP. Is on a lookout for a new constituency.

D.C. SRIKANTAPPA, BJP,



KARNATAKA:
Claims to
have been
suffering

from a spinal problem due to which he had been advised against travelling. Though B.S. Yeddyurappa offered to fly him there, his family stuck to what the doctor ordered.

MANORAMA MADHWARAJ,



BJP, KARNATAKA:
She
says she
supports

"nuclear energy". Had been with the Congress for 40 years before switching over to BJP in 2004. Is now said to be heading back "home" to the Congress.

HARISINGH N. RATHOD,



BJP,
MAHARASHTRA:
Claims to
have gone

home to take his diabetes medicine as his sugar levels had dropped on the way to Parliament. Was admitted in a Delhi hospital and discharged after voting.

SUKHDEV SINGH LIBRA,



SAD, PUNJAB:
Argued
that the
party voted

against UPA under BJP's pressure. Says his conscience did not allow him to vote against a Sikh prime minister. SAD chief Badal claims Libra has sold himself.

CHANDRABHAN SINGH



(BHAIYA),
BJP, MADHYA
PRADESH:
Claims

that he vomited blood inside Parliament itself and had to be rushed to the hospital. Some believe that he is worried about his seat going to a rival.